

Layering some food photos *behind* the text can totally work, as long as we treat them like **soft watermarks** instead of “real” images. The key is: **text always wins, images are just ambience**. Here’s how I’d do it without blowing past 1–2 pages or wrecking readability.

1. Overall Print Layout (still 1–2 pages)

Keep the compact cookbook layout we just sketched:

- Title + date range at top
- Days stacked one after another
- For each day:
 - “PREP AHEAD” (short)
 - “COOK TODAY” with bullet-style recipes + ingredients on just a few lines

This alone gets you into the 1–2 page range. The images are then layered *under* that content as light accents, not separate blocks that take extra vertical space.  What To Cook

2. Theme & Background Style

Visual theme idea: “Warm Kitchen Weekly”

- **Background:** very light warm beige (#fdf7f0) instead of pure white.
- **Headings:** dark espresso brown (#3b2f2f) for “WEEKLY COOKING PLAN” and day names.
- **Subheads** (“PREP AHEAD”, “COOK TODAY”): muted brick or terracotta (#b2563f).
- **Body text:** near-black (#222) for high contrast.
- **Accent lines:** thin sage green (#a3b89c) separators between days.

This gives it a “nice cookbook on the counter” vibe without being noisy.

3. Using Food Images as Watermarks (Behind Text)

Pick 3–4 **hero meals** for the whole week (e.g., one from Tue, Thu, Sat).

For each of those days:

- Place a **large, faint photo** behind the entire day’s block.
- Desaturate it (make it mostly grayscale) and lower opacity (~5–10%).
- Let text sit on top of a slightly opaque white panel so it’s always legible.

Conceptual structure

```
<section class="day day--with-hero">  <div class="day-content"> <!-- Tuesday header, PREP AHEAD, COOK TODAY text --> </div> </section>
```

Print CSS idea

```
@media print { body { background: #fdf7f0; font-family: "Georgia", "Times New Roman", serif; } .day { position: relative; margin-bottom: 12px; padding: 8px 10px; border-top: 1px solid #a3b89c; } .day-hero { position: absolute; inset: 0; width: 100%; height: 100%; object-fit: cover; opacity: 0.06; /* very faint */ filter: grayscale(70%); z-index: 0; } .day-content { position: relative; z-index: 1; background: rgba(255, 255, 255, 0.88); /* keeps text readable */ padding: 4px 6px; } h2, h3 { margin: 0 0 2px; color: #3b2f2f; } .subhead { font-weight: 700; text-transform: uppercase; letter-spacing: 0.05em; color: #b2563f; } li { margin: 0 0 1px 1.2em; } }
```

Because the image is absolutely positioned **within the same vertical space as the text**, it doesn’t add height, so your page count doesn’t increase.

Also, if the user’s browser ignores background images in print (common), this still prints as a clean, readable 1–2-page cookbook layout.

4. Don’t Show Every Meal as an Image

Exactly as you suggested: only a few meals get images.

Guidelines:

- 1 hero meal per 2–3 days is plenty.
- Choose visually distinct dishes (e.g., colorful salad, creamy pasta, smoothie).
- If two hero images would overlap on the same page, scale them down or make one smaller and aligned to one side.

For non-hero days, omit .day-hero entirely — they print as pure text, which keeps things consistent and efficient.

5. Subtle Extras

If you want a bit more “cookbook polish” without cost in space:

- Add a **thin line + small icon** (e.g., knife/fork) between days.
- Use a **drop cap** for each day’s first letter (“T” in “Tuesday” slightly larger).
- Add a tiny footer: “Week of Dec 9–15 • Grocery App” in 8pt at the bottom.